DINESHBHAI BHIL, 45

Archer and archery coach, Bhil tribe

Early in his life, ace archer Dineshbhai Bhil had taken aim at his career goals. Even though he could study only up to Class IX due to acute poverty, Dinesh found his calling while playing with his desi bows and arrows in his native Chhota Udaipur district of Gujarat. His special archery skills helped him shift to a Sports Authority of India (SAI) centre at the state's Devgadh Baria, and later to Delhi and Kolkata. In between, he tasted multiple successes, winning a gold and two silver medals in the 1996 and 1997 National Archery Championships respectively. In 2005, he set up the Eklavya Archery Academy in the tribal-dominated Naswadi tehsil of his district. His students, including his 18-year-old daughter Tejal, have won many national championships.

"WE MUST FREE OURSELVES FROM OUR REGRESSIVE TRADITIONS AND THEN EDUCATE EVERYONE. EDUCATION HAS BECOME THE GREATEST LEVELLER, LETTING OUR CHILDREN ACHIEVE ALL THEIR DREAMS"

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

